

“... THROUGH GOD'S POWERFUL AID, WE HAVE BECOME ONCE MORE TRUE GERMANS.”

Adolf Hitler, German chancellor, 1933



Adolf Hitler being greeted by his followers at the annual Nazi Party rally at Nuremberg in September 1933—it was a celebration of his rise to power.



IN GERMANY, AT THE END OF

JANUARY, after backroom negotiations with the conservative clique of politicians and army officers surrounding the president Paul von Hindenburg (1847–1934), Nazi leader **Adolf Hitler (1889–1945)** was invited to become **Chancellor** (head of government). The conservatives believed they would have Hitler under their control, since only three members of the coalition government were Nazis. Hitler, however, celebrated his appointment as if it was a revolutionary **seizure of power**.

On February 28, the **Reichstag building in Berlin burned down**.

The fire was blamed on a Dutch communist named Marinus van der Lubbe. It provided a pretext for an **Emergency Decree** that gave the government and its police almost limitless powers. The Nazis fell short of a majority in elections five days later, but on March 23, with the support of the nationalist and Catholic parties, Hitler won a parliamentary vote for an **Enabling Act** that **transferred all authority** from the Reichstag to his government. The German parliament had voted for its own destruction; Hitler soon banned all other political parties, and created a **single-party state**.

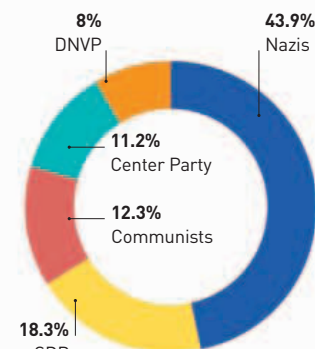
The consequence of Nazi rule soon became evident. The first improvised **concentration**

Jewish boycott

A Nazi Stormtrooper, accompanied by an elite Schutzstaffeln (SS) soldier, posts a notice on a Jewish shop window—“Don’t buy from Jews!”

camps opened in March; in April a one-day nationwide **boycott of Jewish businesses** was enforced; and in May the German Student Association organized the **burning of books** described as “un-German.” These highly publicized acts were just the beginning. As the protection of the law was withdrawn from communists, socialists, and Jews, hundreds of **opponents** of the regime were **murdered** and thousands tortured and beaten.

Nazi violence troubled many Germans, but support for the regime was guaranteed by a sharp turnaround in the economy and the rapid disappearance of mass unemployment. This



German election results

The Reichstag election of March 1933 showed stubborn support for the communists and the socialist SDP despite intimidation.



was partly achieved through ambitious public works programs, most prominently the building of a network of autobahns (highways), that provided employment. There was also a **restoration of confidence**, through the Nazis' projected image of Germany as united, powerful, and dynamic.

The US also found a strong, new leader in the person of President **Franklin D. Roosevelt** (see panel right). In his inauguration speech on March 4, Roosevelt told Americans that “the only thing we have to fear is fear itself.” He immediately applied this principle to the tottering US banking system. **On March 6 every bank in the US was closed**. The president announced that banks would not reopen until the federal authorities had established they were solvent.

Reichstag fire

A Dutch communist was executed for causing the fire at the German parliament building, but many believe the Nazis were responsible.

